

**THE
SUCCESSION
GAP NO ONE IS
READY FOR**

**MOST COMPANIES
HAVE SUCCESSION
PLANS. FEW HAVE
SUCCESSORS**

**“READY LATER”
LEADERSHIP FAILS
IN REAL-TIME
TRANSITIONS**

**PIPELINES
WEAKEN AS TOP
TALENT REFUSES
TO WAIT**

**EXTERNAL CEO
HIRES OFTEN
REFLECT INTERNAL
GAPS, NOT
STRATEGY**

**FUTURE-READY
LEADERSHIP IS
BUILT THROUGH
EXPOSURE, NOT
SUCCESSION
CHARTS**



CORPORATE TRENDS • SUCCESSION

SEARCHING FOR THE NEXT LEADER

**SUCCESSION PLANNING IS NOW
A BOARDROOM PRIORITY, BUT LEADERSHIP
PIPELINES ARE STILL STRUGGLING TO
KEEP UP WITH DISRUPTION, SHIFTING SKILLS,
AND UNPREDICTABLE EXITS**

BY **MAMTA SHARMA**

WHEN INDIGO FACED a sudden leadership churn earlier this year, the spotlight wasn't just on who would take charge, but on who was ready. With CEO Pieter Elbers stepping down amid operational challenges, Founder Rahul Bhatia stepping in as an interim measure, and a global search bringing in Willie Walsh, the current Director General of IATA and former CEO of British Airways to take over later in 2026, the episode has unfolded like a real-time case study in succession.

It raises a simple but uncomfortable question: when leadership transitions happen, is there truly someone next in line?

At Air India, recent leadership transition conversations have once again highlighted how difficult succession becomes during large-scale transformation. CEO Campbell Wilson's decision to step down has triggered a leadership transition at a time when the airline is grappling with operational disruptions, rising costs, and the fallout from the 2025 Ahmedabad Dreamliner crash that severely impacted the carrier. While Wilson had reportedly informed Chairman N. Chandrasekaran about his intent to step down as early as 2024 and continues to remain in the role until a successor is identified, the airline has now constituted a board-led committee to oversee the search. The episode underlines a growing reality for organisations globally: even when transitions are anticipated, building a truly ready-now leadership bench during periods of transformation and crisis remains one of succession planning's toughest tests.

Globally, Apple's transition from Steve Jobs to Tim Cook remains one of the rare examples where succession planning worked almost exactly as intended. Jobs may have appeared irreplaceable, but years of internal grooming ensured continu-